world arrested as much by its Buddhist monuments, as by the destruction of this magnificence in the name of a supposedly retrogressive Islamic iconoclasm.[35] In light of Bamiyan's modern notoriety and its cultural and political resonances, its true physical presence is commonly collapsed into the narrow area of UNESCO designation. Bamiyan's overall importance seems towering enough to be timeless, so that the basin's actual history and geographical extent fade into the hazy mists of memory and imagination.

The historical town of Bamiyan had in fact sprung up due to its command of a basin extending roughly 50 km east–west, with a maximum width of 15 km. It occupied the perfect position for travelers as they embarked on or concluded journeys through difficult mountain passes, which were and continue to be dangerous yet unavoidable challenges in traveling between Central Asia, Bactria, and northwestern India. The principal Bamiyan valley constituted "the great capital of a royal kingdom" according to the seventh-century Chinese pilgrim Hsuan Tsang (602–644 CE).[36] But a more accurate historical conception of the locale would encompass the basin as a whole, including the associated valleys of Funduqistan, Fuladi, Kakrak, and Nigar (Figure 3.8), and the traversable passages to its west extending ultimately into Ghur.[37] Furthermore, if the remarkable large-scale artistic and architectural patronage at the site of Bamiyan is any indication, its transregional significance came into being no earlier than the mid- to later sixth through tenth centuries CE (see below).

It is true that the location of Bamiyan northwest of Kabul, essentially on the India axis from Balkh and Qunduz (*via* Kabul and Gardiz), assured the area some traffic from the early centuries CE as the combined result of commerce and Buddhist proselytism. To wit, archaeological explorations of Bamiyan's valley floor have recovered the remains of freestanding structures, most likely Buddhist monasteries, whose occupation has been assigned to the third through fifth centuries CE. Then a century-long lapse intervened, though afterward the monasteries were reoccupied, and continuously so from the sixth through the late tenth centuries CE.

However, the dates of Bamiyan's two famous colossal Buddhas, once standing within painted niches in the principal valley's cliff face, do not span the entire period of the valley's domination by Buddhist monasticism; rather, they were made during a specific historical moment. Art historians have dated these monumental works to *c.*550–600 CE, based on stylistic comparisons of the Buddhas' sculpted forms with more securely dated works. Additionally, recent ^{14}C analyses of surviving organic materials from the Buddha sculptures verified these conclusions.[38] The remarkably abundant, consistently high-quality and large-scale artistic patronage throughout Bamiyan's valleys as of the later sixth century CE arguably signified a greater concentration of economic and political resources in the area as well.

The Bamiyan basin's increasing prominence in the mid-first millennium